

ASSASSIN'S FALL



ALWIN TWAC

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ASSASSIN'S FALL

a spy raven's gamble

Alwin Twac

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PROLOGUE

A tendril of lightning forked down the dark spring sky, heralding a loud rumble that sounded like a displeased god. Raindrops splashed against the mansion windows in a slow, quiet rhythm that started as hesitant knocks and gradually transitioned into a loud and heavy downpour.

Inside the princess's quarters, however, the air was silent and warm. Amber candlelight bathed the room in a romantic hue, the flickering flames casting long, dancing shadows across the high ceiling. Somewhere within the shadows, Dale waited.

The shadow assassin watched as First Minister Trax laid princess Lianthe on the bed. Trax gently peeled off Lianthe's undergarments, his composure betraying nothing of his mounting lust.

With practiced grace, Trax began sowing small diamonds and gemstones all over her body, occasionally planting soft kisses on her delicate ivory skin. The stones were cold to the touch, and though the princess did not understand the significance of such a gesture, she yielded to the thrill of it. After all, she had granted Trax the honor of taking her innocence.

Dale observed with cold patience. Killing had never stimulated him, even when it applied to those who deserved it. Trax certainly deserved it.

The man below was by no means a true First Minister. He was a fellow assassin whose special skill lay in charm and seduction. The Guild had tasked Trax with infiltrating the small kingdom of Zenwald, but in a fatal twist of events, the kingdom's princess had charmed him instead. Forsaking his duty for love, Trax had used his skills to escalate in political rank, naively believing that the security of a royal title would shield him from the Guild's judgment.

"I love you, Lianthe," Trax cooed, hovering above the princess.

"I..." the princess whispered. The words froze in her throat.

Dale peeled off the ceiling. Gravity and momentum pulled him down and morphed his shadow form into physical existence. A flash of silver cut through the amber light. A spray of warm blood splashed on Lianthe's face.

Trax's heavy, motionless body collapsed on top of her.

Lianthe recoiled, her mind unable to comprehend the sudden nightmare.

"Trax?" she stammered.

The veil of confusion gradually tore from her vision. Where Trax's handsome face and curly blonde hair used to be was nothing but a bleeding stump. A few yards away, resting on the floor and staring upward with a dreamy, vacant gaze, was Trax's severed head.

Lianthe wanted to cry out, to scream for the guards, but the only thing that was still responsive was her eyes.

A tall, lean man dressed in a black leather garb casually walked from nowhere towards the head. He sheathed his sword, his blade clicking with quiet finality. He retrieved a canvas bag, picked up Trax's head by the hair and shoved it inside.

As an afterthought, the man spared a fleeting look at Lianthe. The lower half of his face was masked, leaving only cold, indifferent grey eyes visible. For a moment, Lianthe's heart stopped beating. Her breath caught, and the room whirled around her.

The dark figure walked towards the window. Lightning flashed once more, illuminating the room in stark white. The light withdrew, and the assassin was gone.

The paralysis thawed from Lianthe's body. The gruesome reality of the cold blood soaking her body sank in.

She screamed.

CHAPTER ONE

~ *the final piece* ~

Dale dragged his feet through the damp undergrowth towards the rendezvous point. The storm had softened into a steady drizzle, but the chill did little to wash away the lingering distaste of the night's work. He hadn't enjoyed killing Trax. Then again, the act of killing had never invigorated him, even when the target was a fool who had practically begged for it. "If I didn't know any better, I'd say you hate the hunt," a female voice called out, thick with a harsh Iceland accent.

Liandra emerged from the shadows of the forest. Even in the gloom, her six-and-a-half-foot silhouette was imposing. Her raven hair was cropped in a messy pixie cut that was meant to make her look severe, but her natural beauty made her appear soft and almost delicate. Until she spoke.

She offered a cruel smirk, casually hoisting a canvas bag to display her bounty of two severed heads.

"I terminated two in half the time you took to take one, and I traveled double the distance," she boasted, her voice ringing with pride. "If anything, I should be the next Guild Master."

Dale didn't respond. He knew she was baiting him. She always did. Her brute strength was second to none. After all, she was one of the rare progeny of the extinct giant race. Combined with her unnatural agility, she was a terrifying force with the longsword. Yet, in all their sparring matches, Dale's sheer speed and keen perception had allowed him to win every time. That fact alone bothered Liandra. She constantly sought to trigger a real fight, desperate to prove that if she truly unleashed the strange, destructive potential simmering beneath her skin, she could break him to the bone in an instant.

"You have grown," Dale commented, his tone flat. "I am impressed. Not many assassins can take down two first-rank targets on their own."

Liandra scowled, the pleasantries visibly annoying her. She wanted a fight, not a compliment. She tossed her bloody bag onto the muddy ground at Dale's feet.

"You've grown weaker in contrast," she spat. "I'd let you carry my sword as well but... you're no longer worthy."

Dale ignored the jibe, leaning down to pick up the bag before starting the trek back towards the Guild.

Liandra planted her hands on her hips, her heavy boots sinking into the mud. She watched him retreating back with a furrowed brow. Something was wrong.

“What happened to you?” she demanded, her voice losing its mocking edge. “It was quite strange when they announced that you were going to be the next Guild Master. You vanished five years ago without a word, and now you just stroll back in and resume missions like nothing ever happened?”

Dale stopped. The rain pelted softly against his dark garb. He turned to face her.

“I came back for my execution,” he said, his voice devoid of emotion.

Liandra raised an eyebrow, genuinely taken aback. “What are you talking about?”

“Think of it,” Dale said. “When I vanished after the suicide mission, everyone assumed I was dead. Someone wanted it that way. When the Guild found out I was still breathing, they sent watchers with an invite. They knew hunting me would cost them a lot of good tools, so they planned this.”

“I don’t understand...” Liandra started. Her mind raced, trying in vain to piece the puzzle together. For all her physical prowess, the tangled webs of Guild politics and strategic plotting were never her forte.

“You don’t have to,” Dale said dismissively, turning away once more.

Liandra’s jaw tightened. She would never betray the Guild. Not for Dale, not for anyone.

Before Dale left, Liandra had followed in his footsteps because she believed he possessed something rare in their dark world: a sense of justice. When he abandoned the Guild – *her* specifically – she had lost that guiding light, treading down increasingly despicable paths just to survive.

Good or bad, it made no difference now. If he was walking into a trap, it was his own fault. Liandra clenched her massive fists, the leather of her gloves groaning under the strain.

“If you die, then you deserve it,” she called after him. “The Guild is no place for weaklings.”

Dale paused. He lifted his head.

Liandra braced herself and shifted her weight. She had simulated this moment a thousand times in her mind – how she would react if he finally fought her seriously. She knew there was a real chance he was capable of killing her before she even perceived his motion. But if she triggered her special skill just in time...

Instead of drawing his blade, Dale laughed. It was a soft, genuine sound of pure mirth that startled Liandra out of her defensive pose.

“You have grown indeed, Liandra,” he said, glancing back over his shoulder. “Well said.”

Guild Master Zay chewed thoughtfully on his lower lip, his aged eyes fixed intently on the hotcht board.

The time sluggishly crawled towards midnight, yet the heavy spring rain had not abated in the slightest. A jagged fork of lightning flashed outside the High Tower window, outlining for but the blink of an eye the sprawling, rain-slicked splendor of New Portbrooke far below. Startled by the sudden thunder, Zay’s black cat abandoned its perch on the windowsill and gracefully made its way to the warmth of the hearth.

Zay's attention, however, remained solely on the game. Hotcht was a modern, unforgiving take on both chess and checkers. It consisted of twelve "minions" that could evolve into powerful "lords" once they successfully traveled to the enemy's backline and survived the perilous journey back to their starting row. It required foresight, sacrifice, and a willingness to send pieces into the slaughter for a greater advantage.

Zay boasted two decades of an unbeaten streak. When it came to true rivals, his firstborn son, Instructor Arxes, was the only opponent who came remotely close to dethroning him. And as it happened, Arxes sat across from him that night, his golden hair catching the firelight.

"It's still your move," Arxes said, offering a smug, confident smile that always irritated his opponents.

"Patience," Zay replied, his voice a low, gravelly hum. His fingers hovered over a wooden minion piece. "On the battlefield, speed can get you momentum, but never victory."

"Tsk. Your favorite pawn would beg to differ," Arxes commented, leaning back in his chair.

Zay finally made his move, sliding his minion deep into Arxes's territory. It was his turn to smile.

"There are times when speed is a necessity," Zay said softly. "But it is unpredictable... and dangerous."

Arxes rubbed his cleanly shaved, square jaw, his smugness faltering for a fraction of a second. "I have a hunch he knows what you are up to. Do you have any tools to contain him if your plans backfire?"

"This one won't," Zay said without hesitation. "See, to use a minion effectively, you need to think like a minion. You must know its flaws and how it survives. I know Dale's weakness intimately. But the real weapon I hold is the fact that *he* does not know that I know. Your move."

Arxes stared at the board. Zay's minion was perfectly positioned to die, but if Arxes took the sacrifice – which he was obliged to do – his next move would dismantle his entire defense in the next three turns. He was smart enough to admit defeat when he saw it.

With a heavy sigh, Arxes began placing the hotcht pieces back inside the board and closed it. He stood up and gave an almost imperceptible nod.

"I could have stayed longer had you brought some wine," Arxes said, moving towards the heavy oak door. "I ought to find some sleep. I'll probably have nightmares of my students dying on the suicide mission you're having me assign them tomorrow."

Zay didn't look up from the empty table.

"There will only be one casualty," he said calmly.

Arxes paused, his hand resting on the iron doorknob. He spared a long, calculating glance at the Guild Master. "And who will that be?"

Zay allowed Arxes a moment to piece the puzzle together, but though Arxes was intelligent, he was nowhere near Zay's level. The Guild Master sighed.

“The giantess Liandra.”

CHAPTER TWO

~ *the wild card* ~

The Assassin's Guild was a machine built on three vital pillars: the *executioners*, who were responsible for eliminating targets swiftly and undetected, the *strikers*, who boasted overwhelming physical prowess and engaged their prey head-on; and the *spell weavers*, who used dark magic to track, disarm and neutralize.

Tamaia possessed no outstanding aptitude for any of those. What she lacked in raw combat ability, she made up for in intellect and knowledge. She had ascended to the very pinnacle of the *watchers*, a minor branch responsible for the Guild's vast spying and communication networks.

As Prime Watcher, her life was one of privilege and deep, suffocating dread. She had direct access to all of the Guild's resources and reported directly to Guild Master Zay. Her usefulness had earned her immense respect, making her one of the Guild's few truly indispensable tools despite her below-average combat skills.

But Tamaia knew the terrible truth. Over her years of service, she had learned that the Guild inevitably severed anyone who outlived their usefulness, or anyone who grew too wild to leash. Her last mission had confirmed it.

She paused by a high, arched window, listening to the relentless rain battering the glass. Despite admiring the terrifying strength of assassins like Liandra, Tamaia harbored a profound gratitude that her own hands rarely had to spill blood. Surviving this life required an unwavering soul and a strong mind. Ten years in the shadows had undoubtedly steeled her nerves, but her heart stubbornly refused to turn to stone.

And as long as her brother drew breath, it never would.

Tamaia closed her eyes, a heavy knot tightening in her stomach. She had to make an impossible choice tonight. She could either betray the last remaining piece of her family to secure her own survival, or she could defy the Guild – an act that would guarantee immediate termination.

Taking a slow, shuddering breath, she smoothed the dark fabric of her robes. There was no more time for hesitation. She shook herself back to reality and stepped forward, pushing the heavy doors into the briefing room to face Instructor Arxes and the fateful mission that waited.

The briefing room was suffocatingly quiet, the air thick with the combined killing intent of the Guild's twelve most lethal officials. They sat around a long, polished obsidian table, shadows clinging to the corners of the chamber.

At the head of the table sat Guild Master Zay, his expression completely unreadable. To his right stood Instructor Arxes, and to his left, Prime Striker Liandra, who thrummed with a barely contained, murderous intent.

And then there was Dale.

He sat completely still, his dark garb seemingly absorbing the dim lighting. He was the soon-to-be Guild Master, yet he looked utterly detached from the gravity inside the room. This fateful mission was meant to determine the future of the Guild, but whether Dale succeeded or not, their world was about to change forever.

"There are three individuals who have recently occupied our kingdom," Arxes began, his voice cutting through the heavy silence. "They are located on the outskirts of Greengrove town. The watchers have informed us that these three are of foreign descent and do not possess any documents to verify their identities. It is assumed they are hostile."

Arxes paused, his gaze locking onto Dale. "Your task is to eliminate them. The Guild Master will retire upon your success, and we will commence the banquet of your ascendance."

"Special information on the targets?" Dale asked.

The cold indifference in his voice made a violent shudder trace its way down Tamaia's spine. She stared at him, a horrifying question echoing in her mind: *Could one retain their humanity, even after killing for so long?* She had to weigh her next move perfectly against this aspect. If she miscalculated his capacity for reason, her life would end the instant she made her choice.

"One male and two females, age unknown," Arxes answered smoothly. "They look human enough."

"That's all?" Dale inquired. His face portrayed nothing to show his surprise that the Guild's vast intelligence network would provide information so deliberately vague.

Tamaia opened her mouth to speak, desperate to interject, but one piercing glare from Arxes stayed her words. The trap was set.

"Do you have any objections to completing this task?" Arxes asked.

"I have none," Dale replied flatly.

"Very well. They are first-rank targets, so you are required to return with their heads as per custom. We are assigning Liandra to assist you," Arxes instructed, a ghost of a smirk touching his lips. "Tamaia will assign a watcher to guide you to their hideout."

This was the moment. The point of no return.

"If I may," Tamaia started, her voice steady despite the frantic beating of her heart.

Arxes nodded.

"The location of the targets might have been compromised, if my latest source is correct," she lied. "I was given a hint to another location. I have a watcher or two who are well acquainted with the landscape, but both of them are currently outside the Guild. I know a detour, and with your permission, I would like to guide them to the Greengrove hideout myself."

A tense murmur rippled through the seated officials. Arxes looked at Zay with a questioning glance. Everyone in the room knew of Tamaia's deep distaste for bloodshed; she rarely went outside the safety of the Guild walls unless it was absolutely necessary.

Zay steepled his fingers, his ancient eyes fixing heavily on her. "Do you understand that your personal safety will be your own responsibility?"

Tamaia bowed her head slightly.

"And that you are equally answerable should the mission fail?" Zay added, his voice dropping to a dangerous whisper.

Tamaia swallowed the lump of pure terror in her throat and lifted her head to look at the Guild Master. "I understand."

"Very well," Zay commanded. "Your return is expected tomorrow by noontide. You may take your leave."

The journey south to Greengrove was not the grand, sweeping adventure Tamaia had once imagined outside the Guild's walls. Following the violence of last night's storm, the countryside felt deceptively tranquil. Their horses trod down a muddy mountain track as the sun molt into the horizon, casting a long, amber hue over the distant, scattered homesteads of the valley.

The silence between the three riders was suffocating. Dale and Liandra rode with the rigid, alert postures of seasoned killers, their combined aura making it abundantly clear that Tamaia was an unwelcome addition to the company. Dale, now in his early thirties, possessed a chilling stillness, while Liandra, slightly younger, radiated a restless, predatory energy. Being in her late twenties, Tamaia had hoped they might find some common ground, but it was painfully obvious they viewed her as a spoiled, incapable bureaucrat who required constant babysitting.

"It's just beyond this town," Tamaia finally said, desperate to break the quiet. "Two miles due north. We should be there long before the fullness of night."

Neither of them spared her a glance.

"Are you always like this?" Tamaia asked, her frustration bleeding through.

"Like what?" Liandra replied without looking back.

"Silent. And... boring."

Liandra scoffed, feigning remorse. "My deepest apologies, Prime Watcher. Dale will sing you a nursery rhyme on our way back. That is, if you live that long."

"Why did you insist on coming?" Dale asked quietly, his grey eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Tamaia swallowed hard. She couldn't tell him the truth. Even if she did, would a man so consumed by bloodlust be capable of reason?

"I have some interests," she answered.

Liandra shot her a furtive, mocking glance. "Interesting," the giantess drawled. She spurred her massive steed forward, pulling away from the group. "Don't be late. I'm going to find a drink."

As Liandra cleared the mountainside thicket and thundered toward the town's main street, Tamaia seized the narrow window of privacy.

"There is something you need to know," she started, urging her mare closer to Dale's. "It's about the targets."

"Speak," Dale urged seamlessly.

"You can't kill them."

Dale finally looked at her. "How so?"

Tamaia's hand reflexively went to her throat. "My words were bound by a spell weaver at the Guild Master's request before we departed. If I speak out of turn, the magic will alert the Guild. But I can help you, Dale. If you wish it. In return, you will owe me one favor."

Dale's expression remained utterly impassive. "Are you worried about my well-being, Prime Watcher? Concern makes an assassin weak."

Curse this man's ego, Tamaia thought, her stomach twisting. *He's going to get himself killed!*

"Tell me," she pressed, her voice trembling slightly. "Would you kill someone if you knew they were innocent without a doubt?"

"Only if the Guild commanded it," Dale answered, his tone as casual as if discussing the weather.

"Even if it's a child?"

"Yes."

Tamaia stared at him in horror. "Why?"

"While the thought of slaughtering children does not please me, I trust the system," Dale explained methodically. "A target will never be placed on someone if their existence is not compromised. The information your watchers provide is verified thrice for accuracy. It makes our tasks bearable. You are never wrong, after all. Or is the Prime Watcher's reputation exaggerated?"

Tamaia's stomach churned at the compliment. She suspected he was praising the watchers just to bait her into revealing more, so she clamped her mouth shut. Instead, she cast a nervous glance over her shoulder. High above, a black bird tracked them from a distance, a tiny blotch of pure darkness against the crimson sky. The watch raven's presence confirmed her deepest fear: Zay hadn't just sent them. An entire backup squad of assassins was following on their trail.

She reserved her words as the busy, paved streets of Greengrove opened up before them.

It didn't take long to find Liandra. A panicked crowd had gathered in a wide circle outside a local tavern. Three large men lay sprawled across the cobblestones, unmoving.

Sitting atop her resaddled horse, Liandra pressed a large glass bottle of wine to her lips. She took three long, greedy draughts, then casually tossed the remainder onto the stones.

The bottle exploded. Shards of glass flew like shrapnel, scattering the terrified bystanders – the exact chaotic effect the striker had hoped for.

“Tastes like watered-down mead!” Liandra spat, wiping her mouth with the back of a leather-clad forearm. “I can’t believe I wasted good punches for this!”

“She really doesn’t know how to keep a low profile, does she?” Tamaia whispered, wincing as she watched a brave townsman drag one of the unconscious men away. The victim’s jaw hung at an unnatural angle.

“She wants her prey to know she is coming. It gives them time to prepare, or to try and flee,” Dale said. Under the flickering illumination of the tavern’s lanterns, Tamaia caught the faintest, darkest hint of a smile on his face. “It’s a terrible move that jeopardizes all strategy, but she claims it makes the hunt more exciting.”

“I find that disturbing,” Tamaia admitted.

“She does not normally assault the townsfolk,” Dale explained, his eyes tracking Liandra’s jittery movements. “She only becomes this violent when she gets... anxious.”

Dale halted his steed and looked back the way they had come, sensing the same shadowed presence Tamaia had seen in the sky. When he turned back to her, his face was an unreadable mask.

“Prime Watcher, I advise you to provide the location of my targets and turn back now, if you value your life,” he warned. “There will be bloodshed tonight.”

Tamaia couldn’t tell if it was a genuine warning or a threat, filtered as it was through his irritating monotone. But she couldn’t turn back. Her real mission relied entirely on Dale failing his.

“I...” Tamaia started.

“Hurry up, you two!” Liandra barked, her voice booming over the quiet street. “The night’s still young and I need to come back for a proper drink!”

They left the town behind, riding eastward into the darkening hills. The outskirts featured scattered, lavish homes built among the hillocks. Following a narrow, paved path, the trio ascended toward a solitary homestead where bright, warm lanterns shone invitingly from the new and trendy hexagonal windows.

“This is it,” Tamaia announced, her voice tight as she tugged at the reins of her mare.

Dale dismounted silently. With practiced efficiency, he stripped away his heavy outer merchant cloak, revealing the sleek, dark assassin garb beneath. The moment the fabric fell away, he seemed to blur and blend with the encroaching night.

“I will be back,” he whispered.

“How many days do you need?” Liandra mocked, but the space where Dale had stood was already empty.

Liandra scowled at the darkness, then turned her aggressive gaze to Tamaia. “Did you know who the targets were?”

“I am the Prime Watcher,” Tamaia answered, lifting her chin to project the pride she did not feel. “Not a lot of information evades me.”

“Out with it, then,” Liandra grumbled, resting a hand on the pommel of her sword. “I hate it when people withhold the good stuff.”

Tamaia let out a long, shaky sigh. She looked back down the mountain path into the impenetrable dark. Her combat senses weren’t sharp, but she could feel the oppressive, looming presence of her spy raven – and the execution squad it guided – drawing closer.

“Trust me,” Tamaia said quietly. “This is one thing you do not want to know.”

CHAPTER THREE

~ *choices* ~

To interact with shadow, Dale yielded his consciousness to the primordial rift. It was an icy, chaotic realm that separated existence from nonexistence, a void that hungered to swallow anything born of light.

Dale merged his senses with the darkness. He felt the rift erasing his physical body and replacing it with sentient shadow. He directed his consciousness into the isolated homestead. Almost immediately, he encountered resistance. The house was blazing with lantern light, the illumination so overwhelming that his shadow could not safely materialize anywhere near his targets. His sense of sight was completely obfuscated, his other senses barely functioning as he desperately searched for a patch of pure darkness. He felt the presence of his targets, but something about their thermal signatures felt profoundly wrong.

Eventually, he gathered his scattered senses beneath a large dining table, where the shadows pooled thick enough to allow a transition. He morphed back into his physical form.

A silver spoon clattered onto the floor from above. A young girl ducked under the table to retrieve it, her hand freezing inches from the metal. Her wide, grey eyes locked onto Dale.

For a fraction of a second, she was utterly still. Then, her delicate features relaxed into a vibrant, jovial smile. She reached forward, her small hands grabbing Dale by the arm, and hauled the Guild's deadliest executioner out of his hiding place.

He didn't resist. Instead, his pale face flushed with a sudden, paralyzing warmth.

"Momma!" the girl called out, her grip surprisingly strong. "I found Dale under the table! He was trying to do those stupid surprises again, but I caught him! Papa, Dale's here!"

Ducibella beamed up at him, holding his arm like a hard-won trophy. To Dale, she wasn't a target; she was a miracle child, and a precious fraction of his own soul.

"Good to see you too, Duci," Dale managed to say, offering a rare, generous smile and tousling the girl's hair.

The dining room was festively decorated, the long table groaning under the weight of stuffed birds, roasted vegetables, and a large apple pie. A tall, brown-haired woman walked in from the kitchen, carrying a steaming bowl of stew. Upon seeing Dale, she gasped, and the bowl almost slipped from her hands.

"Dewdrop!" she cried with joy. The bowl clattered carelessly on the table. The woman crossed the room in an instant, throwing her arms around him in a fierce embrace.

Dale blushed furiously. "Don't... call me that, please. I'm old enough to be Duci's father."

"And still my baby boy," the woman reproved affectionately, her grip unyielding.

Danette pulled back, holding Dale by the shoulders, her silver eyes shining. "I was wondering if you'd crack the last cipher in time. Greengrove wasn't exactly easy to encode. But I must admit, I was suspicious when your friend visited us yesterday..."

Dale's blood ran cold. The warmth of the room vanished, replaced by the icy chill of the primordial rift. "Friend, you say?"

"Yes," Danette said, her smile faltering slightly as she registered the shift in his aura. "A tall fellow. Clean-shaved, golden hair fairer than a pixie's..."

Arxes.

The realization hit Dale like a physical blow. Dale hadn't tracked them here. He had no idea they were in Greengrove. Arxes had intercepted Danette's trail, cracked her cipher, and visited them under the guise of friendship just to ensure they would welcome an unexpected guest. Zay hadn't just given Dale a mission; he had orchestrated a perfect play in psychological torture.

Despite being well past her prime, Danette remained one of the very few people on earth who could sneak up on Dale and land a successful blow. Decades ago, she had assassinated her way to the absolute pinnacle of the assassin world, becoming the first female Guild Master in history.

Some of the higher ups had conspired against her, trapping her in a decoy mission and leaving her to burn in a sealed chamber. The man who saved her had been one of the Guild's first rank targets, but after months of nursing the fallen Guild Master, he convinced Danette to forsake vengeance and start a new, peaceful life.

Because of that dark past, Danette never stayed in one place for long. She knew the Guild's reach. They constantly relocated to obscure, unsuspecting corners of the continent, leaving only the subtlest of ciphers and dead-drops that they assumed only Dale could track.

Danette's fine-tuned assassin instincts, dulled by years of peace but never truly gone, flared to life. She saw the horrifying truth written in her son's grim expression. Her eyes darted to the window, the shadows, and finally back to Dale's hands, which hovered near his sword. She suddenly looked very frail, and vulnerable.

Duci, sensing the abrupt, heavy silence, looked up inquisitively, her small hands still clutching Dale's sleeve.

Dale could end them painlessly in a fraction of a second. Theoretically. All his life, he had been loyal to two things: the Guild, and his family. Two things that were not supposed to coexist, yet he had transformed the worst cardinal sin into an anchor that kept him from being completely consumed by the primordial rift. He had kept his origins a secret, but Zay and Arxes had bested him in the end. For the first time since joining the Guild, the executioner faltered.

Danette swallowed hard. Tears spilled from her piercing silver eyes, but her voice was remarkably steady.

"Do what you have to, dewdrop," she whispered.

"What was that fuss about, Duci?" a cheerful male voice called out from the kitchen. "You know apple pie requires strict monitoring..."

Crestien stood in the doorway, wiping flour from his hands. He had relaxed into the life of a vegetable farmer over the years, gaining a soft, comforting weight that made him wheeze whenever he was surprised.

"D-Dale..." the healer stammered. "What an unexpected surprise... I didn't think you'd come on such short notice."

With unnerving calm, Dale unsheathed his sword. The metallic *shing* echoed grimly in the warm room. He recalled Tamaia asking him if he would kill an innocent child for the Guild. He had said yes.

"Dale," Crestien said cautiously, his paternal warmth giving way to dread. "What's going on? You're scaring me."

Heavy footsteps approached from the porch outside. Judging by the interval and the sheer weight of the tread, Dale knew exactly who it was.

"I am sorry," Dale said, his voice breaking.

Ducibella finally let go of Dale's arm, shrinking back toward her mother. Danette placed a fierce, protective arm over the girl's shoulder, her eyes locking onto the entryway.

The heavy wooden front door splintered and snapped off its hinges, the massive panels flying into the dining room.

Liandra stepped through the wreckage, her longsword drawn, the rain dripping from her giant frame.

"Dale!" Liandra called out, her voice booming with manic glee. "Has anyone ever told you it's a bad habit to share a meal with your targets before you slit their throats?"

Dale turned. In that fleeting second, he mapped out every conceivable scenario. Every single path ended in blood. Yet, strangely, the suffocating weight that had pressed against his chest for the last decade vanished. He was no longer tied to the Guild, nor was he bound by their unyielding rules.

"I can't do that, Liandra," Dale said quietly.

Liandra paused, her eyes narrowing as she swept her predatory gaze over the room. She weighed her targets, calculating their potential through the invisible thrum of their auras. The old man held almost nothing. The woman, however, radiated a sharp, suppressed energy strangely similar to Dale's. And the child... Liandra saw the striking resemblance immediately. The coldness of those grey eyes, paired with the fiery potential enclosed within.

"So it comes down to this," Liandra mused, a twisted, delighted smile spreading across her face. "I knew the Guild was up to something, but never in a million thoughts did I consider this a possibility. Who knew you had such a beautiful family?"

"I don't wish to fight you, Liandra," Dale said wearily, his shoulders dropping as he held his sword low.

The giantess laughed, a harsh, grating sound. She raised her longsword, her eyes burning with fierce determination. "Neither do I. But see, there was another condition to this mission that Arxes conveniently left out of your briefing. Should you fail to complete the mission, I am entitled to take over. And if I execute you and bring your head along as well, I will be eligible to become the Guild Master."

Dale's grip tightened on his hilt.

"I suppose you also suspected we were being followed," Liandra continued gleefully.

"Twenty assassins are at the ready outside. Five bowmen, five executioners, five strikers, and five spell weavers. Even if I wanted to let you walk away, my hands are tied here."

"Would you let me leave if I assured your safety afterwards?" Dale asked in a final, desperate attempt to appeal to a good side he knew was rarely present.

Liandra only scoffed in response. "I knew you had grown soft. To be frank, I was on board with the Guild's plan the moment they offered me the deal. It's too sweet to refuse. I'll see you on the other side, Dale."

She was beyond reason. The Guild had thoroughly corrupted her. Whichever missions they had given her after Dale left had eroded what little humanity she had left.

In a terrifying burst of speed, Liandra charged forward. But she did not aim for Dale. Her massive blade swept towards the young girl.

Before the steel could connect, a devastating force slammed into the back of Liandra's calves, sweeping her feet completely off the ground. As she fell, the same shadowy momentum hurled her backward, crushing her massive frame mercilessly against the masonry of the wall.

Danette seized the opening, grabbing Ducibella and pulling Crestien toward the safety of the kitchen.

Watching her prey flee only invigorated the striker. Liandra recovered almost instantly and charged forth with renewed vigor.

Dale stepped into the chokepoint to confront her. "You cannot escape, even if you get past me," Liandra warned, shifting her sword into a brutal two-handed grip.

"I know," was all Dale said.

The room was too bright for Dale to fully utilize shadow motion, which inhibited most of the tools in his arsenal. Liandra's blade rang violently against his, the sheer impact sending a paralyzing jolt racing up her arms. Frustrated, she channeled her raw strength to her upper body, willingly sacrificing her balance for overwhelming aggression.

She thrust forward, and as Dale moved to parry, she flawlessly transitioned the maneuver into a devastating overhead assault. She chopped down with all her might, driving the heavy steel toward Dale's skull with a velocity that even a shadow user shouldn't have been able to match.

Dale didn't dodge. He lifted his unarmed left hand and caught the blade directly by the razor-sharp edge, his expression impassive even as it bit into his glove and rift-condensed skin.

Liandra's momentary surprise gave Dale the fraction of time he needed. He executed a decapitating arc with his own sword, simultaneously jerking Liandra's blade towards himself. He forced the giantess into an impossible choice: hold onto her weapon and lose her head, or abandon it to avoid the lethal assault.

Liandra let go.

Stumbling back, the striker drew two jagged daggers from her belt. She circled Dale, reassessing her prey. She couldn't gauge his current might; he had clearly evolved during his five-year absence. Her best option was to call for the backup squad outside, but her ego forbade it.

She released *havoc*.

Her muscles bulged. Her temporary fatigue dissipated quickly. The rush of strength felt intoxicating, like hot water flowing through every part of her skin all at once. Her hesitation cleared and in its place was a sheer, ruthless aggression. She closed the distance in a blur, thrusting a dagger straight for Dale's midriff. Dale backpedaled methodically, launching Liandra's blade at a lantern above him and fluidly dipping into Liandra's own shadow to morph directly behind her.

Before she reacted, Dale drove his blade clean through her abdomen.

It was a clean strike, but it had initiated physical contact. And in that brief, fatal moment of connection, Liandra's *havoc* bloomed.

The giantess gasped as the dark essence of shadow motion flooded her veins. Her massive body felt terrifyingly weightless, her senses and reflexes accelerating into light speed sentience. Using his own momentum against him, she slipped right off his blade, spun in a blur of motion, and planted her dagger deep under Dale's ribs.

Before Dale could even register the pain, she ripped the blade free and subsequently drove the second dagger deep into the side of his neck. Dale staggered backward, his hand flying to his torn throat as he collapsed onto his back. Blood slowly pooled on the floorboards.

Liandra retrieved her discarded longsword and towered over him, her chest heaving. Her muscles still shivered from the use of Dale's shadow motion. The sensation was enthralling. She raised her heavy blade high, intending to take his head in one fell swoop.

Thwip. A sharp, icy pain stung the back of Liandra's neck, sinking deep into the muscle until she felt the cold metal lodging on her neckbone. A heavy, chemical fatigue washed through her veins. Her eyes rolled back into her head. Her consciousness fled, and the giantess reeled, crashing heavily to the floorboards.

Tamaia stepped out of the entryway, armed with a couple of sleek throwing needles.

"I bought us a minute at the most," the Prime Watcher said breathlessly, staring at the fallen giant. "Liandra will not sleep for long. Her kind has a monstrous resistance to poison."

Dale pointed towards a nearby lantern. Tamaia grabbed a rag and smothered the flame. The room dimmed. Dale drew fiercely from the shadows, using the primordial energy to stitch his torn flesh back together. The heavy bleeding at his neck and ribs gradually stopped. He staggered to his feet, massaging his ribs.

"I can help you, if you accept my terms," Tamaia said, her voice shaking but resolute.

"We can talk later if we survive," Dale rasped.

"Don't be slick, executioner," Tamaia warned, raising another needle. "Do you accept *my* terms?"

Dale glanced at the door, sensing the menacing presence of the backup squad shifting outside. "I accept," he said wearily.

"Fine then," Tamaia said. "Take me to your family."

The watcher had known about this all along. Dale made a mental note to interrogate her later, provided they both survived the night.

He led Tamaia into the kitchen. In the far corner, Danette stood rigidly, armed with a pair of long, wicked carving knives. She looked ready to gut anyone who stepped through the doorway, but her fierce anticipation dissolved into maternal terror when she saw Dale enter, clutching a red patch of cloth against his side.

Tamaia didn't waste time on introductions. She walked past the family towards the stone hearth, methodically throwing back the heavy wooden chairs and kicking away the woven rug. Beneath it lay a small, square trapdoor that blended flawlessly with the floorboards. After a sharp click or two, the trapdoor snapped open, revealing a narrow, pitch-black staircase that plunged deep into the earth.

"I will go with them," Tamaia informed, her emerald eyes meeting Dale's. "But you need to buy us some time before you follow. Do not linger. I will wait for you on the other side."

A small weight crashed into Dale's side, making him wince. Ducibella wrapped her thin arms tightly around his waist, burying her face into his bloodied tunic. She held on with a desperate strength until Danette gently, but firmly, prised off the young girl and guided her down the dark staircase.

Crestien paused at the threshold. He looked back at his son. Neither of them was good at expressing their feelings. They shared an awkward, quiet bond, but the deep affection beneath it was absolute, an unspoken truth that anchored Dale to his humanity.

The old healer gave a tight, trembling nod.

"Be careful," Crestien whispered, and then he vanished into the darkness.

Dale gently lowered the trapdoor, the latch clicking softly into place. He pulled the rug back over the wood.

When he walked back to the ruined dining room, he found Liandra exactly where she had fallen. The giant was asleep, but not for long. The best thing to do was to end her while she was helpless, yet Dale did not humor that thought for an instant. Liandra had been right. He had grown soft.

Dale pulled out a chair and sat. With his family out of the way, he needed not worry about yielding to the primordial rift. The heavy, restrictive chains of his self-control began to snap. And when the final link severed, anyone stupid enough to be near would have a first-hand experience of hell.

With a bizarrely calm interest, he surveyed the feast his family had prepared for him. The stuffed birds, the grilled pig, the roasted vegetables – all of it cooked for naught. Ignoring the blood soaking his collar, Dale picked up a knife, sliced a generous piece of the apple pie, and took a bite.

He smiled, a boyish, childish expression. The old man never lost his touch.

Outside, the dense presence of the backup squad finally closed in.

The assault was novel. The Guild didn't fight dangerous targets by ignorantly storming in as a wild crowd; they implemented a synchronized strategy. In the darkness, the spell weavers initiated their bindings from a safe distance, while bowmen launched projectiles to pin the target in place. Once restricted, the heavy strikers engaged, followed immediately by the executioners delivering the lethal blow. No human, no matter how strong or skilled, had ever survived a multi-pronged Guild attack.

The windows shattered inward in a chaotic explosion of glass and wood. Assassins poured in through every aperture like dark smoke, their blades drawn and gleaming.

Four arrows tore through the air.

Dale closed his eyes, feeling the void consume his existence as he shifted the entirety of his presence into the primordial rift.

By the time the first arrow reached him, he was already immaterial. The projectiles passed harmlessly through his fading silhouette, thunking heavily into the plastered wall.

The Guild had trained to fight executioners, giants, and mages. They had never encountered a target without a physical body, or at least one that they could not counter. Spells and bindings washed uselessly over the rift. Save for Liandra, who lay unconscious on the floor, not a single assassin within his vicinity could touch him.

The drawback, however, was losing his sentience for as long as that form prevailed. It had no mind, no conscience, and its sole purpose was to destroy anything born of light.

The assassins looked like immobile sculptures. Using his enhanced senses and perception, Dale mapped the exact location of each assassin within his scope, and counting Liandra out, they indeed summed up to twenty. Dale's consciousness slipped, and the primordial being began its hunt.

CHAPTER FOUR

~ *delirium* ~

Celia watched, her body trembling so violently she could barely draw breath. This was meant to be her second mission as a fully-trained assassin, but it had descended into an absolute massacre.

None of them had expected this. Instructor Arxes had confidently assured the squad that everything would go according to plan. The spell weavers were supposed to lock the target down from a safe distance, easily eliminating the threat if the strikers somehow lost control.

But the spell weavers had been the very first to die.

The moment the target stepped out of the ruined house, the magical bindings had simply washed over it. Celia had watched in paralyzed horror as the five weavers lost their lives; either getting their heads ripped off their necks or their stomachs shredded open by dreadful claws.

The night air, previously sweet with spring rain, now reeked of hot blood and torn viscera. The unknown creature had systematically slaughtered anyone foolish enough to breach the house, and then it had effortlessly hunted down those who remained outside. A couple of panicked novices had broken rank and attempted to sprint for the horses, only to be torn limb from limb before they even made it halfway down the paved path.

Celia tried to think, desperately clawing for a strategy, but her rational mind had already fled. Her special skill was creating and manipulating illusions. She almost laughed through the terror. A “special skill”, they had said. Where was the specialty in manipulating light and energy, when it could not save her in her time of need?

Huddled tightly beneath a thick, thorny hedge that traced the path toward the homestead, Celia silently cursed herself for ever dreaming of becoming an assassin. Attempting to stand and fight was a guaranteed way to die in an instant. She held her breath, careful not to make a single sound as the blood curdling screams of the squad’s last victim abruptly gurgled and died out.

Her heart drummed furiously against her ribs. She knew that she was next.

A cold, dark patch of nothingness passed over her hiding spot. It landed lightly on the paved cobblestone path a few yards from her hiding spot.

Celia squeezed her eyes shut and remained completely still. For a long, agonizing stretch of time, there was absolute silence. No wind howling through the valley, no rustling of the wet leaves. Nothing but the furious throb of her heart through her ears.

Terrified of what she might find, she forced her eyes to open.

Standing on the path was a towering, humanoid creature. Its form constantly writhed and melted into the darkness, unstable and hungry. As Celia watched, the monstrous entity abruptly fell to its knees, clawing at its own head as it emitted an agonized, echoing roar that chilled the blood in Celia's veins.

The distorted voice was gradually replaced by a very human groan. Right before her eyes, a solid, physical form materialized where the writhing darkness had been.

A lean man pushed himself laboriously to his feet, swaying slightly as he eyed his bloody surroundings.

"Were you sent to kill me also?" the man spoke. His voice was low, clear and chillingly emotionless.

He turned his head, looking directly through the thick branches of the hedge and straight into Celia's hiding place.

"I... I don't want to kill anyone," Celia whispered, her voice cracking as she hugged her knees tighter to her chest. Hot tears spilled down her cheeks. "I just want to live."

The man took a slow step toward her. Celia shrank back into the thorns, begging the earth to open up and swallow her whole. She knew she was a disgrace to the Assassins' Guild. A true striker would have stood bravely against this creature, weapon drawn. But what was the point? She had no hope of winning, and she was going to die exactly like the coward she was.

The man knelt gracefully in front of the hedge. He had cropped dark hair and a pale, gloomy face. His eyes caught the faint moonlight, glowing with a soft, eerie luminescence like two miniature moons.

"The Guild will execute you if you return empty-handed," the man stated factually. "They might even torture you to get the answers of what happened here tonight. I can relieve you painlessly right now, if you wish it."

Celia sobbed, a painful lump rising in her throat. Was this really her fate? There was so much she still wanted to experience in the world. Reflecting back on her short existence, she wondered what life could have been if she had *not* made the naive choice of walking the path of an assassin.

"I don't want to die," Celia mumbled. "Please. I'll do anything..."

The man stared at her for a long moment, his eyes unreadable. Eventually, he stood up and turned his back on her, walking away towards the ruined house.

"Don't be anywhere near this place when Liandra wakes up," the man warned from a distance, not bothering to look back. "She'll be in a very bad mood."

The subterranean passage was cold, smelling of damp earth and ancient roots. As Dale followed the narrow tunnel away from the homestead, the heavy, icy residue of the primordial rift slowly bled out of his system. The transition back to his physical form always left him feeling hollowed out and dangerously exhausted.

The tunnel gradually sloped upward, leading him to a small clearing in the middle of a dense forest. The rain had subsided into a misty drizzle. To his left, a steep embankment rose up to the edges of an old stone bridge. Not far ahead, veiled by a thin, ghostly curtain of spindly trees, a stream flowed down to his right, the water rushing loudly over smooth stones.

There was no one in sight. For a tense moment, Dale's hand drifted toward his hilt, his paranoid mind wondering if Tamaia had played him, or if something had gone terribly wrong.

"Up here," a quiet voice called from the bridge.

Dale scaled the muddy incline with ease, finding the Prime Watcher waiting for him in the shadows. She stood alone, her eyes scanning the tree line behind him with a strange emerald luminescence.

"Where are they?" Dale asked, his voice rough.

"Safe," Tamaia answered, her tone tight. "For now, at least."

Dale closed the distance between them, desperate for details, but Tamaia lifted a long, silver needle, pointing the poisoned tip directly at his chest.

"Don't even think about it," she warned. "I had a carriage waiting here the whole time. A servant of mine drove them away to my hideout. I won't be so accommodating if you try to play tricks with me, executioner."

The last of Dale's unnatural composure finally shattered. The sheer manipulation of the entire night boiled over. "You knew the targets were my family!" he fumed, his voice rising above the sound of the stream. It was the first time Tamaia had heard him speak like an actual human. He took a deep, shuddering breath, trying to soothe his breaking nerves. "Did Zay task you to finding them?"

Tamaia didn't flinch. "I am the Prime Watcher," she said coldly. "When Arxes cracked your mother's cipher, the ripple in the intelligence network was impossible for me to ignore. I knew exactly who he had found, and I knew exactly what trap Zay was setting for you. I positioned myself to guide this mission so I could intercept it."

"You were behind all this..." Dale accused, stepping into the needle's range.

"Don't threaten me! I'm sick of your intimidation," Tamaia fired back, her eyes flashing with defiance. "Kill me and you will never see your family again. You owe me. I saved your life, and I saved your family. I have become a hunted fugitive where I could have easily collected a handsome bounty for this mission. The least you can do right now is be thankful."

The watcher's words hit him like a physical blow. She was right. Dale was simply so furious at his own miscalculations – at being outplayed by Arxes and Zay – that he didn't know who else to blame. Tamaia had desperately tried to warn him on the road, but his own arrogance had been the logs jammed in his ears.

Dale had never needed anyone's help before. Being outsmarted and subsequently saved by a weak watcher was a humbling experience. That aside, he owed her far more than his life.

He hesitantly lowered his hand from his hilt. "You said you wanted to ask for a favor?"

Tamaia lowered the needle slightly, though she didn't sheathe it. "Yes. Did anyone follow you?"

"A lot of ghosts, maybe?" Dale replied.

"Liandra?" Tamaia inquired, ignoring his morbid humor.

"She was still asleep when I left."

Tamaia's jaw tightened. "You should have killed her. You know she will not rest until she finds you to finish what she started."

"I know," Dale said submissively. "Are we going to linger here all night, then?"

Tamaia looked back down the dark passage exit one last time, as if she expected a nightmare to come crawling out of it. Satisfied they were alone, she sheathed her needles.

"Follow me," she ordered.

Dale followed Tamaia silently down the muddy road, their path leading them far away from the town of Greengrove and towards a jagged range of mountains. The further they progressed into the foothills, the less inhabited the terrain became. They passed empty fields and overgrown vineyards at first, until the clearing finally gave way to a dense, ancient forest.

Only when they had fully entered the suffocating darkness of the brush did Tamaia finally speak.

"I want you to accompany me and my charge to the country of Tauria," she stated, her crisp voice cutting through the quietness of the woods. "You will be our guard, and your responsibility will be to protect us at all times. Deliver us safely to Tauria, and I will consider your debt settled."

Dale blinked, surprised by the simplicity of the demand.

"That's it?"

"You will get more information as we go," Tamaia said cryptically, not looking back at him. "But for now, that's all you need to know."

They followed a narrow path up the steep side of the mountain. The vegetation grew so overwhelmingly thick that the trail became barely discernible, though Tamaia navigated the treacherous footing with practiced ease. Under the heavy forest canopy, the darkness was absolute, making it practically impossible for a normal human to see. Fortunately, Dale's senses, still heavily refined from his time in the rift, pierced the oblivion effortlessly.

The path squeezed tightly between two massive, jagged rocks before flattening out at the lip of a narrow cave entrance. The tunnel within was pitch black at first, but a warm, steady amber light beamed from the far end.

Dale followed her toward the light, and as they stepped over the threshold, his breath caught in his throat.

Before them stretched a colossal subterranean hall that expanded horizontally for as far as the eye could see. High above, massive bulbous crystals clung to the cavern ceiling, bathing the entire underground city in a bright, soothing amber glow. The vast floor resembled a

sprawling, exotic marketplace, buzzing with life as people moved freely in and out of multiple arched entrances that lined the walls.

But it was the people themselves that commanded Dale's attention. They were unnervingly beautiful – thin and tall, with skin that was impossibly bright and pale. Their long, intricately braided hair cascaded freely down to their elbows and waists, exposing ears that slanted gracefully away from their heads, tapering to elegant, pointed ends. Dressed in flowing, light silk garments of mesmerizing, unimaginable colors, they matched the ancient legends Dale had heard of the mythical woodland folk.

Dale turned to look closely at Tamaia for the first time in the clear light. He saw the intricate deception she wore every day at the Guild. She used a strange, textured makeup to make her flawless skin appear rougher, and she deliberately tied her hair back in a tight, low ponytail to completely conceal her pointed ears. Yet, beneath the disguise, her true nature was suddenly undeniable – the delicate arch of her thin eyebrows, the luminous glow of her emerald eyes, and the fluid, weightless elegance with which she moved.

"We don't normally bring strangers from the outside," Tamaia whispered, her tone cautious as she looked out over her city. "Hopefully, I don't come to regret it."

As she led him through the bustling hall, the air grew thick with the intoxicating scent of petals and sweet nectar. Dale watched in quiet awe as some of the folk worked on bizarre, intricate machines that crackled and sparked with contained lightning, while others sold pears larger than a man's head. The locals spared the newcomers curious glances, bowing their heads respectfully as the disguised Prime Watcher passed.

Tamaia turned right, guiding him down a straight passageway plastered in smooth, red mortar. Strange, elegant inscriptions lined the walls in a flowing language Dale could not read. The passage branched out, and as they took the right fork, the walls gave way to arched residential doorways, some veiled only by sheer linen cloths.

Suddenly, a small girl dashed out from one of the rooms, giggling, and flew directly into Tamaia's arms.

"Tammy! What did you bring me?" the girl demanded happily.

The Prime Watcher lifted the child, gently tousling her curly auburn hair before setting her back down. Tamaia dug into her pocket, producing a few copper coins. "Go get yourself some honey cake," she said, forcing a weary but genuine smile.

Tamaia watched with a distant smile as the girl sprinted away on her shopping adventure. When she turned, she noticed the bewilderment on Dale's face. Her cheeks flushed a deep red. "We are not all cold-blooded killers like you," she snapped defensively.

Dale actually chuckled, the sound foreign and rough in his own throat. "Your aversion to bloodshed is well known in the Guild."

Tamaia turned on her heel and marched away, visibly offended. She parted a blue cloth on one of the rooms and walked in.

Inside, the home was moderately furnished, leading to a deeper inner chamber where a squat wooden table sat low to the floor. Seated safely on furry rugs around the table were Danette, Crestien, and Ducibella.

"I trust that Mariele brought you here safely?" Tamaia asked as she entered.

Danette looked up, profound relief washing over her face at the sight of her son.

"She did," she answered gladly. "She must have felt uncomfortable in our company though. She left the moment we arrived. But Timmy has been excellent company, so I suppose we got a fair trade."

Dale finally noticed the fourth figure at the table – a young boy with curly blonde hair falling to his shoulders, his slanted ears poking through the locks. The boy blushed deeply at Danette's compliment.

"Forgive her," Tamaia said softly to Danette. "We are a shy people, and we're not used to the company of strangers. Please, make yourself at home."

Tamaia disappeared through another veiled doorway. Dale sank heavily onto a mat beside his family. Duci immediately snuggled close, resting her small head against his arm. She looked up at his bloodstained clothes and the brutal, closing wound on his neck.

"You are not well," she said sadly.

"I'll be fine," Dale promised quietly.

"I... see you," a small, hesitant voice interrupted.

Dale looked across the table at Timmy. The boy's pale green eyes were locked in Dale's direction, but they were milky and unfocused.

"I am blind," the boy explained, shrinking back slightly. "I don't usually see. But... I see you."

Before Dale could ask what the boy meant, the veil parted. Tamaia returned, having exchanged her dark assassin's garb for a long, sleeveless dress of fine magenta silk. Her chestnut hair was untied and it cascaded in long ripples down to her elbows. She placed a fresh basket of fruit on the table and sat beside Timmy.

Throughout the remainder of the meal, Tamaia spoke animatedly about the rich history of her people, offering a warm, convenient distraction to pull their minds away from the blood-soaked reality of the homestead.

As the hour grew late and exhaustion finally settled over the table, Tamaia guided Danette, Crestien, and Ducibella to their sleeping quarters.

Once the family was settled, Tamaia returned, draping two thick, woven towels over her arm. She gestured for Dale to follow her out.

"You are stained with blood," Tamaia explained, her emerald eyes dropping to his ruined, stiffening tunic. "You need to cleanse before you sleep."

The watcher led him through a series of quiet, winding passageways until the ambient air grew thick with sweet-smelling steam. They arrived at a corridor lined with private bathing rooms. Tamaia beckoned him into an unoccupied chamber, sealing the door behind them.

Within the room sat a deep, sunken vessel filled with steaming, crystal-clear water. Dale observed the intricate, polished metal mechanisms mounted on the wall; they were designed to draw both hot and cold water directly into the basin. While the Guild possessed similar, crude contraptions, the woodland folk had clearly mastered a far more refined and

elegant version of the technology. Blocks of fragrant soap and natural scrubbing sponges made out of special tree bark rested neatly on the smooth stone edge of the vessel.

Dale's muscles were numbed, and some throbbed with a sickening ache. The hot bath looked agonizingly tempting, but Dale could not afford to drop his guard. Not yet.

"Remove your clothes," Tamaia instructed casually.

Dale stiffened.

"Get out first," he replied.

Tamaia scoffed, a deeply amused sound.

"Don't tell me the Guild's deadliest executioner is shy."

"A man's dignity lies in his nakedness," Dale muttered, his rigid assassin mindset violently clashing with her casual impropriety.

Tamaia laughed. Without a shred of hesitation, she shed her fine magenta dress, letting it pool softly on the stone floor around her feet, and stepped gracefully into the steaming vessel. Dale averted his gaze, rigidly staring at a blank patch of plaster until the gentle splash of water confirmed she had settled entirely beneath the surface.

"It is just a bath, executioner," Tamaia said, leaning back against the smooth stone. "There is absolutely nothing that I find attractive about you. If anything, I find your brutal methods of killing and your impassive character repulsive."

"That's... cold," Dale muttered, finally turning back.

"You're the one to talk," she countered. "Come. The sooner we rest, the sooner we can leave tomorrow morning."

Feeling profoundly exposed, Dale unbuckled his sword belt and stripped away his ruined assassin's garb. Tamaia did not bother stealing glances. After all, she was a watcher, so she watched without a shred of shame, though she mercifully spared him some commentary. Dale stepped into the scalding vessel and sank down on the opposite end, finding involuntary relief in the soothing heat and the slight concealment the water offered.

For a long moment, the only sound was the gentle lapping of the water.

"Timmy was born blind," Tamaia said quietly after some time. Her tone had lost its teasing edge. "He was there the night our parents were killed, three years ago. Some sort of shadow demon was sent by the Guild to execute them. Timmy was hidden in a closet when it happened. It's the only thing he claims he's ever seen... until he looked at you today."

The implication hung heavily in the steam.

"Do you think I killed your parents?" Dale asked, his eyes locking onto hers.

"No," Tamaia answered honestly. "But someone like you did. Maybe someone worse. The primordial power you draw upon consumes, Dale. It is slowly transforming you into something... ugly."

"I will keep that in mind," Dale replied, the memory of the recent massacre outside the Greengrove homestead still fresh in his mind.

Tamaia's serious demeanor shifted on a whim, replaced by a wicked, calculating glint. She swam closer, pushing a sponge across the water towards him.

"Come closer," she ordered. "I want you to help me bathe."

Dale recoiled, pressing his back hard against the stone edge. "What? No!"

Tamaia burst into a carefree, unrestrained laughter. She found immense pleasure in humiliating him. Here, completely stripped of his armor and his shadows, she held all the power. Every time she teased him, she chipped away at his emotionless mask, forcing the deeply buried, human part of his nature out into the open. Here, he was just a confused little boy who had made a lot of bad choices.

"It's a small price to pay for saving your family," Tamaia reminded him, her eyes dancing with mischief. "Need I remind you that you owe me?"

Dale did not know how to react. The rigid rules of his entire existence consisted solely of his fealty to the Guild and his unspoken affection for his family. With the Guild no longer relevant, his entire worldview was in conflict. He did not know how to navigate the unknown, messy variables of human emotion.

"You can either help me out," Tamaia threatened playfully, "or I can call Mariele to come and join us."

"Were you always this improper?" Dale asked, feeling hopelessly cornered. His heart made an unusual pulse in his chest. He did not like it.

Tamaia's laugh echoed in the humid chamber. "Don't worry about the first time, your hands will be tense. You'll get much better with plenty of practice."

"I agreed to your terms without arguing," Dale grumbled, staring at the soap that Tamaia placed in his hand. "Why are you doing this?"

Tamaia smiled warmly. "It's going to be a very long journey to Tauria," she said, her body only a few inches from his. "This is the fastest way to get acquainted."

"I will forgo this part if it is not mandatory," Dale muttered, feeling exploited.

Tamaia did not budge. She simply presented her back to him and waited, a mischievous smile playing on her lips. Dale closed his eyes, willing the primordial rift to consume him there and then. He wondered if sparing his family's lives had been worth subjecting himself to this very specific, agonizing brand of torture.

CHAPTER FIVE

~ a new path ~

Instructor Arxes stormed into the Guild Master's office, the heavy oak doors slamming shut behind him.

The old man sat comfortably in his high-backed leather seat, methodically stamping his seal of authorization on a stack of pending assassination requests. His terrifying calm in the face of disaster only aggravated the instructor's irritation.

"You miscalculated!" Arxes snarled, slamming his hands down on the polished desk. "On top of losing my entire squad of students, your blunder cost us everything! What's more, your lapdog is completely off the leash now. He'll come back to bite you."

Zay did not stop stamping. Dust motes danced lazily past the shaft of golden morning sunlight that filtered through the parting of his dark curtains, cutting straight through his desk.

"Your anger will not solve problems, Arxes," the Guild Master said evenly. "It will only cloud your judgment. Do take a seat and tell me exactly what troubles you."

"I will tell you myself," a deep, furious voice echoed from the doorway.

Liandra walked in, her massive frame filling the entryway, her expression grim and her armor heavily dented. She closed the door behind her and walked towards the Guild Master, bypassing Arxes entirely without acknowledgment. She casually tossed a small object at the Guild Master. Though old, Zay's reflexes naturally moved to catch the projectile.

"Does it look familiar?" she demanded.

Zay set his stamp down. He observed the needle clinically, noting the detail on the silver texture, the unusual length, and the tip that was coated in a dull, sticky residue.

"This belongs to Tamaia, the head of the watchers," Zay mused. "She is the only assassin in our ranks who relies on sedating projectiles, if my memory serves correctly."

"She betrayed the Guild," Liandra stated, her hands clenching into fists. "She must have wanted something from Dale. The rest of your assassins were slaughtered, and all but one survived."

"A watcher's report confirmed the lone survivor is a novice executioner named Celia," Arxes informed them, his jaw tight. "She must have escaped the affray when the other assassins engaged. Rest assured; she will be caught in short order. We will punish her accordingly."

"Dale escaped, along with the targets and the traitor," Liandra spat, humiliated by the fact. "I could have eliminated them all had your watcher not interfered."

Zay settled his calculating gaze onto the striker. "Is that your excuse for failure, Liandra?"

"Don't give me that!" Liandra blustered, stepping closer to the desk. "This is entirely your fault! You sent us off with insufficient information, knowing full well that I'd be forced to fight Dale! Did you wish me dead also, old man?"

"To be frank, I am surprised you came back unscathed," Zay commented. "Do you care to explain how that came to be?"

Gritting her teeth, Liandra thoroughly briefed them on the entire incident, careful not to leave out a single detail. She knew that if she withheld anything, she would be subjected to the Guild's inquisitors, who would use severe, agonizing measures to extract the truth from her mind.

"If I did not know any better, I'd say you helped him escape," Zay commented when she finished. "But I believe your account. Our grand strategy simply did not take into consideration the absurd possibility of Tamaia's betrayal."

"Even if you had known, the fodder you sent still would have died," Liandra growled. "They were crushed like bugs, and most of them died attempting to flee."

"I see," Zay said calmly, stroking his salt-and-pepper beard. "I assume you did not barge in here just for idle chat?"

"I came to tell you that I am going after Dale," Liandra declared. "And I shall return with five heads."

"There is no need," Zay replied, waving a hand dismissively. "I need you on another, far more pressing mission. I have already summoned a reaper to go after Dale."

Liandra paused, her bravado faltering slightly. "*A reaper?*"

"We only have two of them in the Guild," Zay elaborated, leaning back in his chair. "We do not use them often, but our situation has become dire."

"Why am I only hearing of this now?" Liandra grumbled indignantly. "And you are the one who supposedly encourages transparency."

"They do not practically exist," Arxes answered, his voice dropping to a hushed, reverent tone. "They are the ghosts of the Guild. Speak of them outside these walls, and you forfeit your life."

"I wouldn't care less about your ghosts," Liandra said. "I am going after Dale. I'll kill you if you try to stop me."

She turned on her heel to leave.

A tall, impossibly slender being clad in a heavy black cloak blocked her path. Liandra hadn't even heard the door open.

"My, aren't you vivacious?" the being spoke. The voice was an unnerving, melodic sound that registered as neither feminine nor masculine. "I like this one."

Carefully, the being pulled back its dark cowl.

Its head was completely bald, its skin an unnatural, ashen grey. The creature possessed an oval, humanoid face marked by an ethereal beauty that made it entirely impossible to

identify its gender. It had huge, pitch-black eyes that looked simultaneously mesmerizing and horrific. It smiled broadly at Liandra, revealing a pair of thin, sharp upper fangs.

"Are you the reaper?" Liandra asked, her hand instinctively clenching into a fist.

"Call me Ebel," the being purred. It dragged a thin, purple tongue across its upper lip, eyeing the giantess with a dark emotion that she could not comprehend. "It will be my pleasure to make your acquaintance on this mission. After all, two swords are indeed better than one."

"I don't –" Liandra started.

"I'll save you the trouble of locating our dear Tammy," Ebel interjected cheerfully, his black eyes gleaming with malice. "I can say I have acquired a specific... taste for her presence over the years. Now that she is no longer of use to the Guild, I'd like to formally introduce myself to her. It'll be a lovely little... family reunion."

Three days had passed since they left the hidden sanctuary of the mountains. The terrain was still fair, but the weather was growing significantly uglier with each passing hour. The sky was bruised, promising a severe storm. A downpour was a tough enemy of progress, and it would undoubtedly give the Guild's surviving assassins sufficient time to catch up.

Danette had ultimately made the difficult decision to leave the country. Staying with the woodland folk would have been comfortable, but their continued presence would expose the innocent, peace-loving people to the Guild's wrath. Being lovers of peace, the woodland folk would be easily exterminated by a coordinated strike.

In the end, Danette chose to flee for Tauria with her family. Once their goals aligned, Tamaia had secured five sturdy horses. Danette rode with Ducibella, Crestien with Timmy, and Mariele, the trusted woodland guide, led the company. Dale and Tamaia followed a good distance behind the main group, ensuring no sudden threat reached the leading company.

As the afternoon heat swelled, Dale and Tamaia rested within the thick undergrowth of a shallow valley to take their rations. It felt strange to Dale, running from the Guild rather than hunting for it, though he had always known it was only a matter of time before it happened.

"You lied, four days ago," Tamaia started, breaking the quiet hum of the forest. "I asked if you could kill innocent people. Or did that not include your family when you said yes?"

Dale stared out at the tree line.

"There would be no reason for me to exist if they died," he replied flatly.

Tamaia studied his profile. "For some reason, I still find it hard to believe that the concept of human emotion applies to you," she said. "Don't tell me it's your love for them that keeps you kicking."

"On the contrary, it is."

"Enlighten me," Tamaia requested, leaning forward.

Dale took a slow breath, the memories dragging him back to a darker time.

"The Guild rejected me when I first applied to become an assassin because my skills were not enough. I wandered across the country, desperately searching for a trainer."

"I have a hard time imagining you falling short. To think there was a time when you were a normal human being."

Dale ignored the jibe.

"I eventually found a crazy old man who lived by himself in the woods. He was a master of shadows." Dale looked down at his own hands. "At that time, I just wanted strength. I was hungry for it. The old man took me as his apprentice and taught me everything he knew."

"He seems nice enough," Tamaia speculated.

"He used to kill as a way of sustaining his own life through the primordial rift," Dale continued, his voice dropping. "One day, a young girl got lost in the woods near where we lived. The old man saw her and wanted to devour her. I couldn't let that happen, and we ended up fighting. I won the fight, but the old man was not the only one who ended up dead."

Tamaia sat in stunned silence, the weight of his confession sinking in.

"I went back home, convinced that I was possessed," Dale said quietly. "My father assured me that I wasn't. The power I had dabbled into would require constant, powerful positive emotion to keep that dark strength on the leash. Shortly after, Duci was born. My father discovered she possessed a strength contrary to my own. Where I have an affinity to shadow, her power actively attracts light. Her proximity purifies the residuals from the primordial rift. I guess I owe her my sanity up to this point."

"That explains a lot," Tamaia breathed, finally understanding the complex, fragile dynamic of his family. "Why did you go back to the Guild, though?"

"You ask too many questions," Dale replied, his emotional walls snapping back into place.

"I suppose that's fair," Tamaia conceded. "We're going to take lodge in a small village due west of here tonight. It's known to provide refuge for all types of outlaws, so keep your eyes open."

Dale suddenly stood up, drawing a jagged dagger from his belt in one fluid motion. "Did you notice that we're being followed?"

"I felt it a day ago, but the presence kept slipping out of my grasp," Tamaia admitted, her hand moving to her needles. "My spy raven did not see anything, and it takes a lot of cunning to escape its eye."

"It's close," Dale said.

He blended his senses with the rich forest shadows, tracing his way back down the trail they had just traveled. He listened past the wind, hearing a frantic pulse and some quiet, exhausted breathing. It was hard to register the thermal signature in the afternoon heat, but he gathered enough information to pin the target's exact location.

Using a flicker of shadow motion, Dale materialized under a large almond tree with exposed, gnarled roots.

Just in front of him, a petite woman in dirty, torn executioner's gear was peering desperately through the trees, seemingly spying on Tamaia's resting spot. She had rusty brown hair trimmed down into a messy pixie cut. She looked to be in her mid-twenties – a neophyte assassin, and a very sloppy one. She was too noisy to be a watcher, and too clumsy to be a Guild messenger.

The small assassin must have felt the heavy gaze on her back, for she spun around. Her body tensed the moment she saw Dale, her hand flying to the hilt of her sword.

"Do I know you from somewhere?" Dale asked, tilting his head.

"Yes... No! I know you, but..." the woman stammered, her eyes wide. Dale could literally hear her heartbeat.

"How did you keep up?" Dale pressed, stepping closer. "It's impossible to follow horses even if you're fast on foot."

"I am a good runner," the woman lied, backpedaling until she felt the cold edge of sharp steel pressing against the back of her neck.

"And what exactly is your business here?" Tamaia asked from behind her, holding the blade steady.

"I... I didn't know anywhere else to go," the woman cried out, lifting her hands. "I am a target of the Guild now, and I thought that... I'd join you."

Tamaia shared a bewildered, exasperated glance with Dale.

"Do as you see fit with her," Dale said, sheathing his dagger. "She is no threat to either of us, so I don't see the significance of killing her."

Tamaia contemplated for a short while, then she mercifully withdrew her weapon.

"You can only accompany us for as far as the next village," Tamaia stated. "After that, you are on your own. If you keep following us after then, I will have no choice but to kill you."

Dale found genuine mirth in Tamaia's pretense. She was all bark and no bite.

"What is your name?" Tamaia asked.

The woman staggered on her feet, looking dazed. "It's..."

Her words stuck in her throat. Her eyes rolled back and she fell forward. Tamaia caught her just in time before she hit the dirt.

"Must be severe hunger and exhaustion," Tamaia observed, carefully lowering the unconscious girl. "We should get her to the village as soon as possible. She'll need some warm broth."

Dale wondered how Tamaia had ever passed her assassin tests when her heart was so tender and caring. Upon reaching the horses, Dale effortlessly lifted the unconscious woman onto Tamaia's horse, and they rode quickly out of the valley. Tamaia's spy raven followed from a distance, though its ability to see was now compromised.

They reached the outlaw village soon after sunset. The place was crude, filled with ramshackle buildings that looked as if they would collapse at any moment. The streets were eerily silent, boasting only one operational village inn. Tamaia seemingly knew everyone and where everything was; she took them directly to the inn and paid for their lodging without drawing unwanted attention.

They were given a cramped room upstairs. Dale laid the small woman on the bed, and Tamaia went downstairs to secure hot food. She returned with something Dale was hard-pressed to call broth, but it served its purpose. Tamaia fed the assassin and soaked bread in wine for her afterwards.

"My name is Celia," the woman spoke after regaining some color. "And thank you for saving me."

"Think nothing of it," Tamaia replied.

Celia sat upright, clutching the rough blanket. "I know it's selfish of me to ask, but please take me with you. I am not a very good fighter, but I am resourceful. I used illusions to conceal myself from you and your watch raven. It's not much, but I can use it to hide you from searching eyes."

"And what would you require in return?" Tamaia asked carefully.

"I will follow you wherever you go," Celia pleaded. "I just want to live."

Dale folded his arms across his chest, leaning against the doorframe. "Why do you want to live so badly?"

"That's the point," Celia replied earnestly, looking up at him. "I don't know yet. I want to find my true purpose, and only then shall I accept death."

Tamaia sighed, her expression regretful. "I am afraid I cannot grant you that wish, Celia. Where we go, the road is far too dangerous. You are a fourth-rank target at the most; the Guild will not prioritize you for the time being. You can use this chance to escape and hide. If you come with us, you will have a target on your back every single day until you die."

Celia looked down at her hands. "I... I understand," she whispered, and she did not press the matter further.

That night, Tamaia shared the lumpy, foul-smelling bed with Celia, while Dale stood a silent, unmoving watch until morning. When it was time to leave, Tamaia gave Celia a small leather pouch that was filled with coin and bade her farewell.

The sun was just rising as Tamaia and Dale set off once more, intending to pick up Mariele's trail. But they had barely made it to the edge of the ramshackle village when a terrified scream tore through the morning air, echoing violently from the inn.

Tamaia halted her steed. Without a word, she turned her horse and galloped back towards the building. She dismounted with haste and burst through the heavy wooden doors, finding Celia struggling against a group of large, unkempt men. By the dark, hungry looks in their eyes, they clearly wanted far more than just her gold.

"Leave her alone!" Tamaia demanded, her voice cutting through the clamor. She drew four long, silver needles from her belt, her stance shifting into an offensive posture.

One of the men turned to confront her, a heavy iron axe swinging lazily in his grip. "You're welcome to join us, sweetheart," the brute sneered.

The man charged. Tamaia flicked her wrist. A needle caught him in the throat. His eyes rolled back, and he lurched off balance, tripping heavily onto one of the splintered wooden tables.

Another lunged, and he fell with a needle in his chest. The men swarmed her. Tamaia danced backwards, striking with desperate precision until she was entirely out of needles. Her hesitation to kill was all it took for the men to get the upper hand.

She wasn't a striker. Without her projectiles, her physical disadvantage was glaring. A muscular oaf caught her off guard, stepping inside her guard and planting a meaty, devastating fist squarely into her stomach.

The brute force of the blow made her knees buckle. Tamaia collapsed against a stone pillar, spitting out a mouthful of hot blood. Her vision dimmed, the edges of the room blurring strangely as Celia cried out for help. Tamaia cursed. *How could she protect her brother from the Guild's elite assassins if she couldn't even fight off a handful of untrained, village ruffians?*

She saw another fist coming through her blurring vision. She tried to duck, but her paralyzed body refused to get out of the way.

She braced herself for the brutal impact. It never came.

Instead, it started raining blood.

A thick, crimson spray painted everything in the room; the tables, the chairs, and the plaster walls. The meaty fist that had been hurtling toward Tamaia's face flew away, attached to a cleanly severed arm.

The heavy thud of the severed limb hitting the floorboards was followed by dead silence.

Dale stood by the entrance, wiping fresh blood from his sword with the innkeeper's dirty dish towel.

"We should be leaving," Dale said. "Something is definitely on our trail."

Tamaia gasped for air, clutching her bruised stomach as she stumbled over to check on Celia, who was buried under a gruesome mass of corpses.

"Do not blame me if things get worse from here," Tamaia said, pulling the terrified girl to her feet.

Celia stood, her knees wobbly. She took in the horrifying, butchered sight before her. But beneath the terror, a slim, undeniable hope took root. If she followed this man, she would survive.

Celia walked forward, her resolve hardening. She was ready to face whatever new life awaited her, even if she had to live as a symbiote for the shadow assassin. She would rely on the strong until she found the courage to walk alone.

CHAPTER SIX

~ the point of no return ~

Liandra detested Ebel with every fiber of her being.

Not only did she fundamentally fail to understand the dark, chaotic nature of the reaper's aura, but she could not comprehend his twisted motives either. Ebel had deliberately refused to disclose his gender, so Liandra had angrily decided to treat him as a man, even though his fluid, theatrical behavior suggested otherwise.

Over the past three days, they had ridden hard from the capital all the way to the lush outskirts of Greengrove. Ebel had casually suggested using a dark spatial skill to transport them instantly, much like Dale's shadow motion, but Liandra had vehemently refused. According to the reaper, Dale and his newly formed entourage had fled deep into the mountains to hide their trail, making tracking a tedious nightmare. To make matters worse, the runaway assassin had apparently followed them, her clumsy but effective *dispersion* skill distorting the trail even further.

Liandra was confident in her own abilities, but the idea of hunting down six targets through hostile terrain did not appeal to her in the slightest. She would have preferred tagging five of her finest strikers along for the hunt, but too many ambitious eyes were watching her like vultures after her recent failure. She was not going to humor them by admitting she was incapable of subduing the targets on her own.

"Where we go, horses cannot tread," Ebel announced, abruptly halting his steed at the rocky foot of a massive mountain.

From their vantage point, a treacherous mountain range spanned forward for several miles, the jagged summits of each peak completely enshrouded in an unnatural, clinging mist. The place looked inherently hostile, and Liandra disliked snakes.

"Are you sure this is where they went?" the giantess asked, a heavy scowl marking her face.

Ebel smiled. The way his thin, grey lips curled sickened Liandra, which only made the reaper's smile broaden all the more.

"I have been tracking rebel assassins since long before you were born, Prime Striker. Do you doubt my tracking skills?"

"Yes," Liandra answered bluntly. "This could have gone easier if I came alone."

"It is quite the contrary," Ebel purred. "My presence serves to ensure that the mission is completed and all loose ends are tied. Unlike the last time."

The deliberate reminder of her recent failure was more than Liandra could tolerate.

In a blur of motion, she unsheathed her massive blade in a quick draw, thrusting the razor-sharp tip directly at Ebel's throat. The reaper did not react.

Liandra stopped a fraction of an inch short of piercing his soft, grey skin with the tip of her blade. "Listen to me, reaper. I am not your friend. Get in my way, and I will not hesitate to cut you down myself. I do not need you to complete my mission."

Ebel licked his lips, his black eyes shining.

"Killing me won't rid you of the pathetic weakness you harbor, Prime Striker," Ebel whispered. "You act all tough on the outside, but buried deep within lies a desperate, scared little girl who wishes to belong somewhere."

"Mind your tongue!" Liandra fumed, her grip tightening on the hilt. "I only failed because I was betrayed by your watcher scum. I will not fail twice."

Ebel casually raised his hand and wrapped his long, pale fingers around the sharp edge of Liandra's blade. The very instant his skin touched the steel, Liandra's body became ice cold. She could not even bat an eyelid.

A paralysis spell? she thought frantically. *No.* As a giantess, Liandra was naturally immune to the effects of simple binding magic.

Was Ebel's special skill *terror*, an ancient, higher tier of magic that could immobilize even demons?

"You had a perfect chance to kill Dale," Ebel said, his expression growing significantly darker. "Tamaia is not honed in the skill of stealth. Your refined assassin senses must have felt her pathetic presence long before she threw those needles, yet you allowed the attack to happen. The Guild Master might have bought your ruse, but I will be watching you closely, Prime Striker. I will be right there to reap your arrogant soul the very moment you inevitably fail again."

A sharp, unfamiliar emotion pierced through Liandra's thick armor of rage. *Was it fear?*

As she considered unleashing havoc to break the hold, the grim, terrifying expression on Ebel's face softened back into a tender, almost loving smile. He casually released Liandra's blade, and the icy paralysis immediately thawed from her strained muscles.

"There is a small errand we need to attend to first," Ebel announced cheerfully, acting as if he had not just threatened to devour her soul. "It'll give you a wonderful chance to vent out that frustration."

It took them over four agonizing hours just to reach the mouth of the sacred cave.

A powerful, ancient enchantment had been woven into the very fabric of the mountain. Whenever Liandra felt they were finally gaining ground, the dense mist would silently shift, and they would abruptly find themselves standing at the exact same spot where they had started: the rocky foot of the mountain beside their tethered horses.

After several infuriating, failed attempts to physically hike through the ward, Liandra had to accept Ebel's proposal. Using his unholy spatial skills to tear through the illusion, the reaper bypassed the mountain's defenses.

They found themselves standing in a dark, cavernous hollow. It was welcomingly warm, the still air smelling heavily of sweet pea flowers. At the far end of the stone corridor, a narrow,

arched entrance glowed with a soft amber light that mysteriously refused to project into the shadows of the cave itself.

Ebel walked towards the archway. After a moment of hesitation, Liandra followed.

Stepping beyond the entrance, Liandra's breath caught in her throat. Stretching out before her was a beautiful, sprawling subterranean city, a place unlike anything the battle-hardened giantess had ever seen. Ethereal beings who looked like ancient elves went about their peaceful business within the glowing marketplace, oblivious to the arrival of their new, lethal guests.

"What is this place?" Liandra asked, her voice dropping to an awe-struck whisper.

"This is the sanctuary where Tamaia sought refuge after she evaded you," Ebel explained, his eyes sweeping over the bustling crowds. "These people are the woodland folk, her true people."

Liandra scanned the faces of the people, her striker instincts searching for threats.

"Are they still here?" she asked, her muscles tensing.

Ebel chortled – a wet, unsettling sound that Liandra did not find entertaining.

"No, they are not that foolish," the reaper answered. "We are not here for them."

Liandra lowered her guard slightly, somehow confused. "Then why are we here?"

Ebel stepped forward into the ambient amber light.

"Allow me to shed light on the grand mystery of the woodland folk," he lectured, his tone almost academic. "These people once lived freely in the outside world, just like everyone else. In the era of the Great Wars, they stubbornly refused to join any nation in taking up arms. Instead, they retreated deep into the mountains and stayed hidden.

"There was a prophecy that they would return one day," Ebel continued. "Given their terrifying cunning and unrivaled mastery of magic crafts, any country that sheltered them would become an overwhelming threat to the neighboring nations. Their sudden emergence would rekindle a continental war. So, according to the Five Great Nations pact of peace, no country was to ever offer the woodland folk any form of shelter."

Ebel watched a group of laughing woodland children run past an archway.

"Of course, we tried to track Tamaia many times over the years, but she lived up to her reputation as the Guild's Prime Watcher. Had she not traveled with someone with a familiar essence, we could not have traced them. Now that we've found our bird's nest, we have two options," Ebel said, holding up a long, pale finger. "The first: we capture them and split them accordingly among the five nations as slaves. But that would tempt the higher-ups with lofty goals to manufacture magical weapons and plant new seeds of war with the aid of the woodland folk."

Ebel held up a second finger. "The second option is to destroy everything and everyone in this abode. And though this is but a fraction of their total population, this absolute act will wipe their trace in our region. It will be like they never existed."

Liandra stared at the reaper in horror. As a striker, she lived for combat and the thrill of matching strength against a worthy foe. This wasn't combat. This was genocide.

"You want us to..." Liandra started, the words turning to ash in her mouth.

"Yes," Ebel confirmed coldly. "There are no warriors among them. It'll take us no time to accomplish our task."

Ebel moved forward into the city limits. As he walked, the pale nails of his fingers elongated, stretching into sharp, cruelly curved claws that appeared to be specifically refined to tear flesh.

The reaper stopped before the wide ramp that led down into the city, turned back towards Liandra, a terrifying, fiery glow igniting in his pitch-black eyes.

"And Guild Master Zay tasked me to observe your performance," Ebel whispered, his fangs catching the light. "Particularly during this incident."

CHAPTER SEVEN

~ the summit of five nations ~

The annual summit of the Five Great Nations was, in Guild Master Zay's esteemed opinion, an agonizingly tedious affair.

The lavishly decorated hall swarmed with soft-handed dignitaries who had traveled from the four corners of the continent. The current year's primary subject was meant to address the shifting trade and economic relations between their respective borders.

Zay observed them all with the detached, calculating gaze of a predator. After all, they were all just pieces in the grand scheme of things.

To the south lay the coastal country of Tarelea, its merchants boasting of direct sea access, rare fish, and exotic foreign goods. From the east came the barbaric, yet wealthy, lords of Varlaron, their lands rich in heavy minerals and fine silk. The western delegates hailed from Rosewald, a kingdom blessed with endless rain and fertile lands that were the agricultural backbone of the entire continent.

And then there was the north, home to the elegant, aloof scholars of Uemalia. Rumors persisted that the Uemali were distant, diluted descendants of the woodland folk, though no historical record validated the claim. Because their small lands were relatively barren, they focused their intellect on refining advanced crafts and technology, loaning their scholars out to develop the economies of the other four nations.

Lilei was the undisputed centerpiece. Positioned dead center on the map, it bordered all four of the great nations, making it universally regarded as the most dangerous kingdom. While a temporary alliance of the other nations could theoretically subdue Lilei's standing army, the looming presence of the Assassins' Guild made such an invasion practically unviable.

Consequently, the king of Lilei had requested Zay's attendance for the sole purpose of intimidation. Zay was well aware that he was nothing more than a highly dangerous ornament. To further enhance the Guild's terrifying aesthetics, he had brought along the deputy primes of each assassin sect.

The summit was held at the Sapphire Elite inn. Beyond its lavish rooms and costly delicacies, it was the single most secure facility in all of Lilei. The visiting royals were under the pretense of safety, blissfully unaware that every single member of the inn's staff – from the bowing doorman to the bustling portly manager – was a fully-fledged, first-rank assassin.

Zay's eyes drifted across the room, finally landing on a familiar face. Princess Lianthe. She represented a tiny, superficially insignificant kingdom within the borders of Lilei, attending the summit in desperate hopes of strengthening diplomatic ties and establishing her small

realm as a viable trade partner. Her kingdom sat on precious emerald mines that sparked greed in all the other nations.

The only reason her kingdom still retained its sovereignty was simply because Zay allowed it. He recalled, with a ghost of a smile, sending Dale to her bedchambers mere days ago to execute her foolish lover. Zay knew the traumatized princess would never dare speak of it; she understood that her very existence, and the fate of her kingdom, rested entirely in the palm of his hand. When the time was right, she would make an excellent sacrificial minion.

"Guild Master," a soft voice interrupted his thoughts.

A serving maiden – one of his own disguised executioners – bowed deeply beside his chair. "Your presence is required on the royal's balcony," she informed him before melting back into the crowd.

Zay stood, grateful for the excuse to get some fresh air. The nauseating perfumes of the clustered nobles and royals were suffocating beyond comfort. He navigated the crowded room, his mind pondering who it was that had the gall to summon him.

He stepped out into the cool night air.

Standing alone on the sweeping stone balcony, overlooking the vibrant, sprawling city far below, was a tall young woman. She wore a pristine white dress, her skin radiant as if it was made out of stars. Her stark white hair fell in waves all the way down to her waist. A golden tiara rested upon her forehead, intricately crafted in the pattern of a twisted branch bearing silver oblong leaves.

To any passing noble, she looked like a holy emissary. But Zay's eyes were far too sharp to be deceived. He recognized the ethereal beauty of her features, the distinct slant of her pointed ears, and the overwhelming, oppressive aura she exuded. A flawless disguise. This creature took amusement in disguising itself as a being of light.

"You summoned me," Zay stated, offering a rigid, slight bow.

"I did," the woman replied. Her voice was firm, carrying the weight of undeniable authority. She sighed, looking at the Guild Master with something close to regret.

"Our plans have changed," the woman said. "There were unforeseen circumstances, and we were forced to hasten our timeline because of such. The monarch of Rosewald brought along a specific vintage of wine to share with the royals at the summit banquet tonight. Let your assassins taste it for poison, and make sure your king drinks it first, toasting to the unity of all the great nations."

Zay's eyes narrowed slightly as he processed the horrific implication.

"He will die the moment it touches his lips, in front of everyone's eyes," the woman continued. "You shall not demand the Rosewald monarch's execution. Instead, you will publicly offer the Guild's help in investigating the poisoning, and you will return with him safely to his kingdom. I will contact you there with more details."

"I do not mean to object," Zay started, a rare edge of tension bleeding into his voice, "but without the king, Lilei will be thrown into a state of pandemonium. National morale will

tumble and the chaos will leave our borders vulnerable to external attacks. The other kingdoms have been secretly training assassins of their own, after all.”

The woman smiled – a cold, terrifying expression.

“Worry not, Master Zay,” she whispered to the wind. “Everything will be reviewed in due time.”

Before Zay gave another strategic excuse, the air shimmered, and the woman vanished into thin air.

The Guild Master clenched his hands into trembling fists. For two decades, he had believed he was the master of the hotcht board, sacrificing lesser pieces to secure his own invincibility. But looking out over the glittering city of Lilei, a bitter, infuriating truth settled over him. He was no longer in control.

There was one thing Zay hated more than losing, and it was being a minion in someone else’s game.